could not be deciphered by me clearly – these varied from 'yes, I believe so' to 'is that so' or 'incredible', and at times just a gesture of his hand on his heart. Maybe I got some of it wrong. Nonetheless, it shall be a memorable interaction for me and my admiration for him as a scholar remains undiminished. However, anyone can go wrong.

Pakistan has gone through turbulent times in its chequered history, but today it faces its biggest challenge, that of the extremist monster created in the 1970s and 80s. The people of Pakistan are standing at the crossroads. They have to decide whether they want to be a moderate and progressive Islamic nation living in peace with their neighbours or let their destiny be decided by the Taliban and Al Qaida and other obscurantist elements. They cannot have both options if they want to move ahead. As discussed earlier, there are many other schisms and contradictions in their polity and society and unless these are resolved in an early time frame, the situation may go beyond control. We hope that this state of affairs changes for the good of Pakistan, and a stable and prosperous nation emerges. On the positive side one can sense certain signs of change in Pakistan, but it is too early to predict.

I am of the firm belief that the time has come for us to reinforce Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's idea of making our borders 'irrelevant' and ushering in an era of peace in subcontinent. We can definitely look at the resolution of all issues in a peaceful manner and dialogue. Therefore, it is to be considered whether India could set the ball rolling for the creation of a subcontinental economic union on the lines of the European Union or ASEAN. I believe that the foundation provided by SAARC could facilitate the creation of such a union. The burgeoning Indian corporate sector could increase its investments in our neighbouring countries and help to create employment opportunities in those countries. That is likely to help in arresting the illegal migration of their citizens to India. We must not forget that even the US has not been able to stop the Mexicans from crossing the border. Consequently, India and Pakistan, as also all other countries in our region, could focus on alleviating the misery of the underprivileged in our respective countries. The region would then be able to witness a period of peace and